

Paying for the growth

Where the capital comes from, what it costs, who to call, and what to put in front of them

The plan needs roughly **\$150,000** to put a second crew on the road at full strength. There are eight realistic ways to get it and they differ by a factor of eleven in what they cost. This is the ranking, the arithmetic behind it, and the names and numbers of the people in Baton Rouge who actually write the cheques.

Two things on this page have dates attached and both fall inside the next two weeks. They are on the next page.

Two things with dates on them

Everything else in this document can wait a week. These cannot.

1. Do not take equity in the same deal as the loan

SBA's new rulebook, **SOP 50 10 8.1**, applies to any loan given an **SBA number on or after 1 October 2026**. If Ned is admitted as an owner as part of the same transaction, the loan stops being an expansion loan and becomes a **change of ownership**. The coverage test then becomes **1.25x measured on historical cash flow**, and projections may not be used to meet it. Against Charlie's filed returns that fails, and the deal dies on a technicality rather than on its merits.

Kept as a plain expansion loan to the existing company with Charlie as sole owner, the test stays **1.1x on historical and/or projected cash flow** - and projections are exactly what this plan has. **Separate any equity admission from the raise by at least twelve months.**

2. The 0% equipment promotions end 30 September

Bobcat is currently running **0% for 60 months on compact loaders and 0% for 48 months on compact excavators**, or **\$8,000-\$10,000 cash in lieu** per machine. Kubota, Deere, Cat and Takeuchi run structurally identical programmes.

It is not really 0%. Giving up an \$8,000 rebate on an \$85,000 excavator to take the 0%/48 works out to an implied **4.93% APR**; on the loader it is **5.78%**. That is still the cheapest equipment money available in 2026 - just not free. **Ask every dealer for both numbers**, the 0% term and the cash-in-lieu, and take whichever is genuinely cheaper. That one question is worth about \$8,000 a machine.

Neither of these is about finding a better rate. They are both about not losing money to a calendar.

The recommendation

\$150,000

borrowed, not raised - no equity sold, no share of the company given away

\$2,218/mo

the SBA 7(a) payment at 12.75% over ten years, if it comes to that

\$1.22M

what borrowing rather than selling 20% leaves Charlie with by year 10

Borrow it. Do not sell a share of the company to fund a second crew.

The case is arithmetic, not preference. Selling 20% for \$300,000 in year 2 hands an investor \$1,492,480 by year 10. Borrowing the identical \$300,000 costs every dollar of interest it will ever charge - \$240,975 - and then stops. **Charlie ends up \$1.22M better off by year 10 and \$3.92M better off by year 15.** Equity would only have been the better call if the company turned out to be worth less than \$1,626,750 at year 5. The plan says it is worth \$2,541,791.

There is a second reason, less obvious and more important. At \$380,000 of revenue with near-zero recorded earnings, **the company has almost no value to price equity against today.** An investor would be buying Ned's forward plan and would price it as though it might not happen - which means demanding a percentage that only looks reasonable if you ignore the plan entirely. Every month the two-crew run rate is real is a month the same cheque costs less of the company. If equity is ever taken, take it after year one is proven, take it as preferred stock with an accruing return rather than common, and use it for something debt genuinely cannot fund.

Worth saying plainly: **institutional minority growth equity does not exist at a \$200,000-\$500,000 cheque size for a non-technology service business.** No fund has that mandate. The realistic sources are family, a local operator with money, or an independent sponsor writing a personal cheque - and each of those comes with a relationship attached that outlasts the deal.

What each source actually costs

Every row borrows the same \$150,000. Compare on the **cost per year borrowed** column, not on total cost - a short loan looks cheap only because it is short.

Source	Rate	Term	Cost/yr	What it is, and what they want
Supplier net terms (SiteOne, Ferguson, aggregate)	0%	0.5 yr	\$0	Free, and the first call. SiteOne bills net 15th prox - roughly 30 days of float. At two crews, materials run \$16,000-19,000 a month, so thirty days of terms is that much permanent working capital at zero cost. A credit application, not a loan committee.
Manufacturer 0% on the equipment (Bobcat, Kubota, Deere)	0%	4 yr	\$0	Bobcat, Kubota, Deere, Cat, Takeuchi. Cheapest equipment money there is. Expires 30 September - see page 2. Implied cost against the cash rebate is about 5%.
Equipment loan, independent lender	8.50%	5 yr	\$6,930	6-14% for a good borrower in 2026. Application-only up to \$150,000-\$250,000: the app, three to six months of bank statements, the vendor quote. Approval in 24-48 hours. The machine secures it; a sole owner signs personally anyway.
Louisiana SSBCI loan guaranty, through a bank	9.50%	10 yr	\$8,442	THE LEAD. Louisiana guarantees up to 80% of a bank loan, fee 0-2%, no application fee. The job test is two jobs above \$100,000 - a second crew is three or four hires, so it is met on day one. Covers equipment AND working capital. A Louisiana bank files it, not you.
SBA 7(a) Small Loan	12.75%	10 yr	\$11,911	Prime + 6.0% is the cap at this size. 85% guaranteed at or below \$150,000. No mandatory equity injection for an expansion. Expect a lien on every business asset, a personal guarantee, and a lien on the house if there is equity in it. 30-75 days.
CDFI / mission lender (TruFund, HOPE, LiftFund)	11%	7 yr	\$9,606	8-13%. Slower and dearer than a bank, far more forgiving on collateral and messy books. TruFund runs contractor mobilisation loans - working capital against signed contracts. Good for a \$50,000-\$100,000 first tranche while the bank deal is packaged.
Bank line of credit (working capital only)	11%	3 yr	\$8,930	For payroll float only, never for equipment. Expect \$25,000-\$50,000 offered. Watch the annual clean-up requirement: most banks want it paid to zero for thirty days a year, which is a trap for a weather-driven business.
Merchant cash advance / daily-debit 'revenue' product	84%	0.75 yr	\$76,276	DO NOT. The factor rate tells you nothing - the term does. Money arrives in lumps 20-40 days after a job closes; the advance debits every business day regardless. New York's attorney general cancelled \$534M of merchant debt from one funder in January 2025.

The merchant cash advance row is not a rhetorical flourish. A 1.35 factor repaid over nine months is an 84% APR; a 1.49 over six months is 171%. On a \$100,000 advance that is \$714 every weekday - about 47% of gross revenue before materials, fuel or payroll. After three rainless weeks the receivables stop and the debits do not. A profitable contractor can be killed by that faster than an unprofitable one can be killed by competition.

The order to do it in

- 1 Open supplier terms - this week**
SiteOne, Ferguson, and every aggregate and pipe supplier. Net 15th prox or net 30. Frees **\$16,000-\$19,000** of permanent working capital at zero interest and requires only a credit application. Nothing else on this list is free. Do it first.
- 2 Equipment credit application - before 30 September**
While the 0% programmes are live. Ask each dealer for the 0% term *and* the cash-in-lieu figure. Finance on a **\$1-buyout lease or a straight loan, never a fair-market-value lease** - an FMV lease forfeits the depreciation deduction and leaves you owning nothing.
- 3 Place equipment in service before 31 December**
100% bonus depreciation is permanent for property acquired after 19 January 2025, and the Section 179 limit for 2026 is \$2,560,000. On a \$138,500 package that is roughly **\$33,000-\$44,000 of tax deferred**. Section 179 is capped at business taxable income; bonus depreciation is not. Confirm the split with a CPA.
- 4 Walk the Louisiana state guaranty into a Baton Rouge bank**
Package built free by the LSU Small Business Development Center, then filed by **b1BANK** or **Hancock Whitney**. The 80% guaranty is what makes a \$150,000 loan worth a bank's time. Allow 30-60 days.
- 5 Add a \$25,000-\$50,000 line of credit**
Payroll float between a job finishing and the homeowner paying. Apply now - banks take 15-45 days. Draw it only for float, and plan for the annual clean-up.
- 6 SBA 7(a) at \$150,000 flat, only if 1-5 fall short**
Not a dollar more. The guaranty drops from 85% to 75% and the fee steps from 2% to 3% at \$150,001 - that single dollar costs about \$1,500. If more than \$150,000 is genuinely needed, the next efficient size is **above \$350,000**, where the rate cap falls from prime+6% to prime+3%. There is no good reason to land in between.
- 7 Never the last row of the table**
No merchant cash advance, no daily-debit product, no stacking. If the business is ever in a position where that is the only option left, the right answer is to slow down, not to borrow at 84%.

The Louisiana money

Louisiana SSBCI Small Business Loan Guaranty - start here Free, and worth more than it sounds

The state guarantees **up to 80% of a bank's loan, or \$1.5M**, with a risk-based fee of **0-2%** and no application fee. Existing businesses need **15% equity**. Eligible uses are equipment, working capital, inventory and facility improvements - refinancing is not. The job-creation test is one permanent job at or below \$100,000 and **two above it**; a second crew is three or four hires, so it is satisfied on day one and it is the single strongest paragraph in the whole package. Turnaround is quoted at one to three weeks for guaranties under \$500,000.

You do not apply to the state. A Louisiana bank, credit union or CDFI originates the loan and files the guaranty. Pick the bank first, then have them file it.

Contact: LEDSSBCI2@la.gov | 225.342.3000 | named programme contact Shamelda Pete, spete@la.gov, 225.342.5683. LED is at 617 North Third Street, Baton Rouge - walkable from downtown.

One caution: the older LEDC page still states 75% and a 1-4% fee while the SSBCI site states 80% and 0-2%. Confirm the current terms in writing before relying on either.

Collateral Support - the fallback

If the bank's objection is that a mini-excavator and a truck do not cover \$150,000 - which for a solo contractor it will be - LED will pledge **up to \$250,000 of cash** into a collateral account behind the loan. Same contact. Ask about it in the same conversation.

LSBDC at LSU - 8000 Innovation Park Drive, Building 3000 | **(225) 578-4842**. Free loan packaging, projections, and introductions to named commercial lenders. No published data says an SBDC referral raises approval odds, and they do not claim it does. What it actually buys is a warm introduction, a package pre-screened for completeness - which removes the most commonly documented decline reason - and a third party who stress-tests the assumptions before a lender does. Use it.

Certifications that cost nothing

- **Hudson Initiative** - construction firms up to \$10M of receipts. State agencies may waive extra-quote requirements under \$25,000, and certified firms get **10% of total evaluation points added to an RFP bid**. Apply at ledsmallbiz.com; reviewed in about two business days.
- **Bonding Assistance** - LED guarantees the surety 25% of contract price or \$100,000. Requires SEBD certification first. This is the door to public drainage work, which is the gate a \$380,000 contractor otherwise cannot pass.
- **Small Business Employee Training (SBET)** - reimburses **up to \$3,000 per trainee per year**. Requires 50 or fewer employees and three years operating in Louisiana. Apply 30 days before training starts. Real money for building crew two.
- **Contractor's licence** - roughly \$510-\$610 all in, and a notarised statement showing \$10,000 of net worth. Cheap. Get it *before* the loan application, not after: a licence plus bonding capacity is what a bank underwrites when it reads a \$2.4M five-year projection.

Who to call

Recent Louisiana SBA 7(a) volume, and what it means for a \$150,000 ask.

Lender	Why them	Watch out for
b1BANK (Business First)	Baton Rouge headquartered, active SBA lender, 30 loans in the trailing year. The natural first call for a local, relationship-driven deal - and the right home for the state guaranty.	Their average loan is about \$923,000. You would be a small file. Lead with the SSBCI guaranty to make the deal worth their time.
Hancock Whitney	Highest in-state 7(a) volume - 49 loans, average \$581,000, around 9.9%. Strong contractor and equipment book. Dedicated SBA team.	Larger institution; get a named banker rather than a branch queue.
Northeast Bank / Readycap	Small-loan specialists. Northeast averages about \$119,000 across 62 Louisiana loans - almost exactly this ask. Readycap averages \$92,000.	Readycap's average rate is around 13.8% - small-ticket and expensive. Use as a backstop, not a first call.
TruFund Financial Services	The most contractor-literate CDFI in Louisiana. Loans \$50,000-\$350,000, plus TruAccess Contractor Mobilisation Loans - working capital against signed contracts. \$33M lent in-state.	New Orleans based (504.884.0607, Louisiana@trufund.org). Slower than a bank but far more flexible.
HOPE Credit Union / Communities Unlimited	HOPE lends up to \$250,000 including equipment and vehicles; Communities Unlimited \$1,000-\$200,000 with in-house underwriting.	Neither publishes rates. Expect roughly 8-13%.
Neighbors FCU	Branches in Baton Rouge, Zachary, Prairieville, Denham Springs, Port Allen and Walker - literally the service corridor. 225-819-2178.	No named lenders published; contact form only.

Do not cold call. It reads as shopping. Go through the SBDC referral or a personal introduction. In the first meeting bring the one-page summary, the sources and uses, the historicals and the projection summary - leave the full binder in the car and offer to send it. Then ask two questions directly: **“What coverage ratio does your credit committee want to see, and do you lend on projections for an expansion?”** and **“Are you an SBA Preferred Lender with delegated authority?”** The answers tell you in about a minute whether that bank is worth three weeks of your time.

What actually kills these applications

It is almost never the rate. It is the books.

A contractor who has spent years minimising taxable income cannot then claim higher cash flow at underwriting. **Lenders underwrite the filed return.** Commingled personal and business spending, cash jobs and informal statements do three things at once: they make the returns understate the real earnings, which is exactly what the coverage ratio is computed on; they raise a quality-of-information flag; and they leave the lender unable to tie the projection to anything. Cash jobs that never hit a deposit are invisible to underwriting - you cannot get credit for them, so the deposit history has to start now.

SBA's credit memo now explicitly requires **the two most recent months of bank activity**, so those two months in particular have to be spotless.

The cleanup, in order

- Separate business account and card, **zero personal transactions**, for at least three months before applying.
- **Twenty-four months** of reconciled bookkeeping tied to bank statements - QuickBooks or equivalent.
- Three years of returns consistent with those books.
- A documented add-back schedule, every item traceable to a specific transaction.
- A written bridge showing exactly how crew two's capacity, close rate and ramp produce the revenue jump. **This is the number underwriters attack.** Consider presenting a conservative case as the coverage basis and the full plan as upside.
- Budget **60-90 days** before the first lender meeting. Rushing unprepared books is worse than waiting.

The coverage ratio, precisely

Test	Ratio	Measured on
7(a) Small Loan - SBA floor	1.10x	historical and/or projected
Expansion, under the Oct 2026 rules	1.15x	historical
Change of ownership	1.25x	historical only - projections barred
Typical bank credit committee	1.20-1.35x	their own policy, stricter than SBA

Assume **1.25x** is what gets it approved, not 1.1x. On \$150,000 over ten years at 12.75% - about \$26,600 a year of debt service - that means showing roughly **\$33,000 of annual cash flow available after the owner's pay**, visible in the returns.

What is negotiable, and what is not

Negotiable: the rate (the SBA cap is a ceiling, not a price - two competing term sheets is the lever), the term (take all ten years; it lowers the payment and raises the coverage ratio), covenant thresholds and cure periods, reporting frequency, and whether life insurance is required below \$350,000.

Not negotiable: the unlimited personal guarantee from every 20% owner, the guaranty fee schedule, the blanket lien when most of the proceeds are working capital. Do not spend capital fighting those.

Refuse or push back on: cross-collateralisation and cross-default clauses - the most dangerous clause in a small-business note, because they quietly turn one default into total exposure; monthly financial reporting for a business with no controller; a flat coverage test applied from month one rather than stepped to match crew two coming online; and any additional-indebtedness clause that would block the equipment financing you are running in parallel. There is **no SBA prepayment penalty under a 15-year maturity** - if a term sheet contains one, strike it.

What to put in front of each of them

Bank / SBA lender	Equipment finance	CDFI / mission lender	Equity investor
In this order One-page summary with the ask, use of proceeds and coverage ratio stated up front → sources and uses → three years of historicals plus year to date → business debt schedule → 24-month monthly projection with an assumptions page → collateral schedule → personal financial statement and resumes → three years of returns. What they actually care about Repayment from business cash flow first, collateral second, character third. A commercial lender forms a yes-or-no lean in about ninety seconds on the ask, the use of proceeds and whether cash flow covers the payment. The mistake Leading with the vision instead of the number. Submitting the fifteen-year model - it reads as unserious. Projections with no assumptions page. Hiding the bookkeeping problem instead of disclosing it with the cleanup already done.	In this order The application, three to six months of bank statements, and the vendor quote. That is genuinely all - application-only tiers run to \$150,000-\$250,000 with no financial statements at all. What they actually care about The collateral's resale value and secondary market, then the personal credit score, then time in business. Construction equipment approves readily precisely because the secondary market is deep. The mistake Sending them a business plan. They will not read it and it slows the file. Use this channel for the truck and the trencher to shrink the bank ask - it improves the coverage ratio on everything else.	In this order Mission fit and job creation first - how many Baton Rouge jobs crew two creates and at what wage - then the standard financial package behind it. What they actually care about Ability to repay, but with real tolerance for thin collateral, imperfect credit and messy history. Several will help fix the books rather than decline over them. The mistake Treating them as the lender of last resort in the room. They know. Mission-fit language is not decoration here, it is the underwriting criterion.	In this order A ten to fifteen slide deck → unit economics: revenue per crew, gross margin per job, cost to acquire a customer, crew payback period → the five-year three-scenario model → the cap table and proposed structure → operator bios. What they actually care about The team and the unit economics. The real question is whether crew two's economics replicate - is this a repeatable unit you can run ten times - and what their exit looks like. The mistake Pitching a loan story (safety, coverage) to an audience that needs a return story (multiple, exit). And valuing the business off revenue rather than earnings.

Timeline to money: equipment finance 3-10 days | bank line of credit 15-45 days | SBA 7(a) through a Preferred Lender 30-75 days | CDFI 30-75 days | equity 3-6 months, and longer at this size because the buyer pool is thin. Add two to four weeks if the books need cleaning first.

What it sells for, and why growing is what changes that

The single most useful correction in this research: **the recurring maintenance book does not raise the multiple at this size.** Pest control - the most contract-recurring home service that exists - sells at **2.04x owner's cash, below landscaping's 2.30x** across 945 recorded sales. Recurring revenue shows up in the *revenue* multiple (0.96x against 0.63x), not the earnings multiple. The plan book is still a good business and it throws off real profit; it just is not what moves the price.

What moves the price is crossing the size thresholds that change who is allowed to buy you.

Revenue band	Who the buyer is	Priced on	Multiple	In this plan
Under \$2M	An individual using an SBA loan. The price is set by what his debt service can carry, not by how good the business is - which is why it sits in a narrow band no matter what.	Owner's cash (SDE)	2.0-2.3x	Years 1-4. Year 1 value \$722,514.
\$2M-\$5M	Self-funded searchers and regional platforms. 83% of self-funded acquisitions close under 5x. Deal count and competitive tension both rise sharply here.	EBITDA, after paying a manager to do the owner's job	4.0x	Year 5. Value \$2,541,791.
Above \$5M	Private equity add-on. Platforms want roughly \$3M of revenue and \$500K of EBITDA before they will look. Typically 50-70% cash, 10-15% earnout, 15-30% rollover equity.	EBITDA	5-8x	Year 10 onward. Value \$7,462,400.

Two details that decide real money. **First**, a financial buyer deducts the cost of replacing the owner before applying the multiple and a buyer who will run it himself does not - that one line is why the same company gets two valuations that differ by a factor of two. **Second**, deals under \$500,000 draw one or two offers while deals over \$5M draw three or more 87% of the time. Competitive tension alone is worth roughly a full turn of the multiple. **Third**, and easy to miss: since June 2025 a seller note in an SBA-financed sale must sit on **full standby for the life of the buyer's loan** - often ten years of no principal and no interest. A headline price with 15% in a seller note is not the price.

How Ned's stake should be built

A vesting profits interest

Scag Scapes is an LLC, which makes this available and makes it the structurally correct answer for an incoming operating partner contributing work rather than cash.

A **profits interest** gives a share of future profit and future appreciation *above a hurdle* set at the company's fair market value on the day it is granted - and **zero claim on everything below that hurdle**. Under Revenue Procedure 93-27 the grant is not a taxable event for either party. Charlie keeps 100% of what he has already built. Ned earns only on what gets created after he arrives.

At a hurdle of \$170,000 and a 15% interest, the model shows Ned's stake worth \$355,769 at year 5 and \$1,093,860 at year 10, while Charlie's share is \$2,186,022 and \$6,368,540. Against a business that stays as it is - worth about \$170,000 - Charlie is ahead by \$2.02M at year 5.

The comparison that matters is not Charlie's share against 100%. It is Charlie's share against what a business that does not grow is worth.

What a CPA and an attorney must handle

- **File an 83(b) election immediately** - within 30 days. Not technically required for a profits interest, but practitioners strongly recommend it: it starts the clock against a later IRS valuation challenge and creates contemporaneous documentation.
- **Have the hurdle valued contemporaneously.** A hurdle nobody can defend is the most common way these grants fall apart.
- The holder becomes a partner: **K-1, self-employment tax, loss of W-2 status**, and additional state filing. Proceeds above the hurdle are capital gain. The company gets no deduction.
- **Alternative if Charlie prefers no partner on the return:** phantom equity - a contractual bonus tracking enterprise value. No equity moves, the holder stays W-2, and the company gets an ordinary deduction at payout, but the recipient pays ordinary rates. Must be drafted around Section 409A.
- **Avoid a capital interest grant** - it is immediately taxable at ordinary rates on full value, so the recipient owes cash tax on something not yet monetised.
- Paper a **put and call at a formula price** at the start, while nobody knows who will want out. The model prices a buyout at \$355,769 at year 5, or about \$8,049 a month over five years.

Remember page 2: a profits interest granted in the same transaction as the loan can reclassify the whole deal. Grant it, but not in the same twelve months.

The first ninety days of capital work

	Days 1-30	Days 31-60	Days 61-90
Charlie	Open a clean business account and card; stop all personal transactions through it. Apply for supplier terms at SiteOne, Ferguson and the aggregate yards. Get the equipment credit application in before 30 September. Start the contractor's licence.	Hand twenty-four months of records to a bookkeeper. Sign the engagement for reconciled statements. Confirm the equipment list and take delivery in time to place it in service before 31 December.	Sit the first lender meeting. Sign the equipment paper. File the Hudson and SEBD certifications.
Ned	Book the LSBDC appointment at LSU. Call LED about the SSBCI guaranty and Collateral Support. Build the sources-and-uses and the one-page summary. Call three equipment dealers for both numbers.	Assemble the full package: historicals, debt schedule, 24-month projection with assumptions, collateral schedule. Get two competing term sheets, not one. Line up the SBDC introduction to a named banker at b1BANK or Hancock Whitney.	Negotiate the term sheet: rate, full ten-year term, covenant thresholds, strike any prepayment penalty, carve out equipment purchase-money financing from any additional-indebtedness clause.
Together	Agree the raise size and stick to \$150,000 or below. Agree explicitly that no equity changes hands in this transaction.	Decide the tranche split: how much on equipment paper, how much on the guaranteed bank loan, how much on the line.	Have an attorney paper the operating agreement amendment and the profits interest - to be granted <i>later</i> , not with the loan. Have a CPA price the hurdle and file the 83(b).
The test at day 90	Clean books running, supplier terms live, equipment financed at or near 0%.	A complete package in a named lender's hands, and a second lender competing for it.	Money committed, equipment in service before year end, and not one percent of the company given away.

The honest summary. This plan does not need clever money. It needs a second crew, roughly \$150,000, and books good enough that a bank can see what the business actually earns. The cheapest capital available - supplier terms, a subsidised equipment promotion, and a state-guaranteed bank loan - covers the whole requirement without anyone giving up a share of anything. The expensive options exist for businesses that did not prepare. Ninety days of preparation is what keeps Scag Scares out of that category.

Sources

Every rate, programme term and multiple in this document was verified in September 2026 against the source listed. Where a figure could not be confirmed, it is marked in the text.

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